

Wild boar

Sus scrofa

- ↔ 3–6 ft (0.9–1.8 m)
- ⚖ 97–440 lb (44–200 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Plant matter, eggs, rodents
- 🏠 



Europe, Asia, N. Africa

The ancestor of most domestic pigs, the wild boar is an example of extreme species success. Now found on every continent except Antarctica, the highly adaptable wild boar is so prolific that it is often considered a pest, largely due to its impact on agricultural landscapes.

Sounders and solitary boars

Whether wild boars are solitary or social depends on their sex. Sows live in herds or “sounders” made up mainly of other females and their offspring. Sows only leave a sounder to give birth, returning as soon as their piglets—litter sizes vary from three to 12—are large enough to travel with the sounder. Sows may have two litters a year, and will protect all piglets in the sounder. Males only come into contact with other boars to mate, although they sometimes join sounders to feed.



▷ STRIPED PIGLETS

Sows give birth to striped piglets that live in the sounder and are protected by the mother. Males leave their birth sounder at one or two years of age.



coat of thick, coarse hair

▷ BRISTLY PIG

Many wild boars have longer bristles on their backs that raise when they are threatened. Hence they are often called razorbacks in North America.

Black woodpecker

Dryocopus martius

Large woodpeckers have daggerlike beaks, crested heads, and stiff tails. A long outer toe turns outward or back, rather than the usual three-toes-forward, one-back shape of other perching birds, giving a better grip for climbing trees. Black woodpeckers need big trees—pine, oak, beech, or mixed forests are all occupied. In winter, they prefer wooded parks and yards. They chisel a new nesting cavity at the start of each breeding season. The eggs hatch in 12–14 days and the young can fledge after 24–28 days.

Noisy neighbors

Black woodpecker calls are loud and frequent, with strident, discordant laughing notes and high, long calls. They proclaim their ownership of a territory by “drumming”—a loud, deep, staccato sound produced by a rapid drumroll beat of the billtip against a branch.



△ HARD AT WORK

A female black woodpecker, with a smaller red cap than the male, chips away bark and living wood to get at the beetle larvae and carpenter ants inside.



stiff tail used to maintain balance

- ↔ 18–22 in (46–56 cm)
- ⚖ 12 oz (340 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Insect larvae, ants
- 🏠 



Europe to Asia